

The Gift in Wartime

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* Understanding the text.

• Answer the following questions.

a) Who is the speaker addressing and why can that person not hear or understand what she is saying?

Ans: The speaker is talking to her husband, a soldier killed in the Vietnam War. He cannot hear or understand her because he is dead. Although she speaks to him as if he were standing there, he is only a memory. The 'gifts' she mentions - like medals and the smell of gunpowder - are all that remain of him. Death has created a permanent wall between his world and her voice.

b) What can you infer about the speaker's feelings for the person addressed as 'you'?

Ans: The speaker feels a profound, aching love for her husband. She treats him with deep respect, offering him her wedding gown and her youth as if they were sacred ~~int~~ items. Her grief shows how much she valued their life together. She feels completely empty without him, as if her own heart stopped.

beating when his did. To her, he wasn't just a soldier; he was her entire world and her only happiness.

c) What is the speaker's attitude toward war?

Ans: The speaker's attitude is bitter and full of irony. She sees war as a cruel exchange that takes away a living, breathing human and replaces him with cold, useless objects like silver stars and medals. To her, war is not glorious or heroic; it is a thief that steals love and leaves behind nothing but shrapnel and sorrow. She views the 'gifts' of war as insults to the person she lost.

d) In what ways do you think this person's fate has affected the speaker?

Ans: The husband's death has destroyed the speaker's future. She feels that her own life ended when he died. She describes her hair turning gray and her world turning from 'spring to winter' showing that her joy has been permanently replaced by mourning. She is left in a state of constant loneliness, where even her wedding dress becomes a shroud. His fate has turned her into a person defined entirely by loss and longing.

Q. What does the speaker promise at the end of the poem? Why do you think the speaker does this?

Ans. At the end, the speaker promises to find him in the next life. She says she will carry the shrapnel that killed him so they can recognize each other in the afterlife. She does this because she cannot accept that their story is over. By promising to meet again, she finds a small bit of hope to keep going. It is her way of proving that their love is stronger than the war.

- Reference to the content.

a) What is the theme of the poem?

Ans. The central theme of "The Gift in Wartime" is the bitter irony of loss and the hollow nature of military honors. It explores how war destroys human lives and personal relationships, leaving survivors with meaningless tokens. The poem highlights a tragic imbalance where a soldier's life is traded for cold, inanimate objects like medals and badges.

The poem suggests that the 'glory' promised by war is actually a source of deep, permanent grief for those left behind. It critiques the idea of wartime 'gifts,' showing that these offerings are merely symbols of a stolen future. For the speaker, the 'honors' bestowed by a nation cannot compensate for the physical absence of a loved one.

Finally, the theme deals with the permanent scars on the heart. For the widow, the war never really ends because she carries her grief every day. The poem suggests that medals are actually a bitter reminder of what was stolen. By focusing on these personal feelings, the author shows that the true cost of war is the endless sorrow found in broken homes and hearts.

b) What imagery from the poem made the greatest impression on you? Why?

Ans: The image that makes the strongest impression is the wedding gown placed over a grave. A wedding dress is a symbol of happy new beginning and a long life together. Seeing this beautiful, "shimmering" dress used to cover a dead body is very shocking. It creates a sharp contrast between the joy of a wedding and the sadness of a funeral, which helps the reader understand the loss.

This imagery is powerful because it shows how war turns a happy celebration into a tragedy. It moves the story of war away from the battlefield and into a person's private life. It represents a stolen future.

The dress was meant for a marriage, but now it sits on a cold grave. It makes the tragedy feel very real & personal, rather than just a story about a war in a far-away place.

Also, the poem uses images like the 'smell of blood' and 'clouds of explosion'. This is a scary change from the 'scent of perfumes' we expect at a wedding. These images help us feel the violence that ended the soldier's life.

c) Which figurative language is used in the poem? What does the person addressed as 'you' give in return?

Ans. The most important figurative language in the poem is irony. The title itself is ironic because a 'gift' is usually something that makes us happy. However, in this poem, the gifts are medals and badges that only exist because someone died. This irony helps the reader see how cold war can be. It shows that these 'presents' are actually just reminders of death and permanent loneliness.

Another tool used in the poem is metaphor. The speaker talks about 'clouds' and 'piece of explosion' that follow her.

These are not real clouds; they are metaphors for her sad thoughts and trauma that stay with her every day because of the war.

Finally, the poem uses Anaphora (repetition of words). It keeps saying "You give me" and "I offer you". This shows the 'trade' that happened. It makes the poem sound like a sad song and helps us see how much more the woman gave compared to what she got back.

Q. What does the speaker 'offer' in this poem? What does the person addressed as 'you' give in return?

Ans. In this poem, the speaker describes a very sad exchange. She 'offers' her youth, her love and her future. She gives her 'shimmering' wedding gown and fresh 'roses' to her husband. These things represent the best parts of her life and her hope for a long time together. By offering these items, she shows that she gave her entire heart to the person she loved.

In return, the person she calls 'you' and the war give back lifeless objects. Instead of a husband, she gets 'silver stars' to wear. Instead of life together, she gets a medal with gray ribbon and a badge. These items are the 'return' for her sacrifice. This is a tragic trade because she offered things that were warm and alive, but she received things made of cold metals.

This exchange shows the cruelty of war. The soldier gives his life, and the widow gives her happiness, but they get nothing of real value back. The 'smell of blood' and the 'cold grave' are the final parts of this trade. It shows that in war, nobody really wins.

Q. An apostrophe is a literary device in which a writer or speaker addresses an absent person or an abstract idea in such a way as if it were present and can understand. Discuss the poem in relation to apostrophe.

Ans. An apostrophe is when a speaker talks to someone who is dead as if they were right there. In this poem, the woman talks directly to her dead husband, calling him 'you'. Even though he is in a grave and cannot answer, she speaks to him as if he is listening. This makes the poem feel very personal.

This device is effective because it shows that the speaker is still deeply connected to her husband. She has not been able to move on. By talking to him, she makes the reader feel her deep loneliness. We see her reacting out into the silence, hoping for a response that will never come from the grave.

Using apostrophe also shows that the dead are never truly gone for those who love them. The husband remains a presence in her life, even though he is just a memory. It allows her to express her sadness directly to the person she lost. This proves that war leaves the living trapped in a conversation with someone gone.